

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Power, Authority and Legitimacy - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Power, Authority and Legitimacy

TEN-SESSION CORE PATH • PRACTICE • OPTIONAL ADVANCED • REGISTER NOTES

1 Power, Authority, Legitimacy and Influence

2 Power Forms, Core Distinctions and Chapter Spine

3 Weber, Marx, Gramsci and Classical Elite Theory

4 Pluralism, Deep Power, Feminism and Constructive Power

5 Comparisons, Traps, Boundaries and Source Discipline

6 Theses, Directives and Perspective Selection

7 Elite-Theory Debate, Evidence and Mark Scaling

8 Digital Power: Panopticism, Data and the Three Dimensions

9 Surveillance Asymmetry, Consent and the Public-Private Boundary

10 Objections, Puttaswamy Boundary and Digital Answer Architecture

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Power, Authority and Legitimacy - Solved Practice Workbook

Generation: learner-v2:g2 **PYQ ownership:** No directly owned verified PYQ is assigned to this topic; all questions below are original practice.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

MCQ 1

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Power**?

- A. the ability to produce intended effects or secure compliance; Gauba cites Russell, Dahl, Wiseman and MacIver to show its coercive and relational dimensions (PDF pp.302-303).
- B. for Gramsci, a form of rule apparently exercised with the consent of the ruled through cultural and ideological domination (PDF pp.306, 310).
- C. the first highlights domination by an agent over a subject; the second highlights the subject's capacity for resistance and self-development.
- D. Robert Michels, in Political Parties (1911), propounded the "Iron Law of Oligarchy": organisations - however democratic their founding aims - tend toward rule by a chosen few because growing size and complexity hand management to professional experts who become difficult to displace.

Answer: A

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Power** with **the ability to produce intended effects or secure compliance; Gauba cites Russell, Dahl, Wiseman and MacIver to show its coercive and relational dimensions (PDF pp.302-303)**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 2

Which concept names the capacity to secure compliance or produce intended effects without implying rightfulness?

- A. C. Wright Mills
- B. Power
- C. C.B. Macpherson
- D. Force / coercion

Answer: B

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **the ability to produce intended effects or secure compliance; Gauba cites Russell, Dahl, Wiseman and MacIver to show its coercive and relational dimensions (PDF pp.302-303)**, with **Power**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 3

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Influence**?

- A. power can compel obedience; authority secures obedience as rightful and beneficial (PDF p.303).
- B. identifies traditional, charismatic and legal-rational authority; the last is central to the modern bureaucratic state (PDF p.303).
- C. a softer capacity to shape choices or conduct without necessarily relying on sanctions; this is the useful exam distinction from coercive power.
- D. in The Power Elite (1956), Mills replaces the Marxian "ruling class" (a single economic class) with "power elite" - three loosely interlocking groups (captains of industry, military leaders, prominent politicians) who occupy the pivotal command posts of modern American society and share social origins, culture and mutual reinforcement, without being reducible to one class (PDF pp.314-315).

Answer: C

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Influence** with a **softer capacity to shape choices or conduct without necessarily relying on sanctions; this is the useful exam distinction from coercive power**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 4

Which concept shapes choices through persuasion, prestige or agenda-setting without direct coercion?

- A. Steven Lukes - the "third dimension of power"
- B. Gandhi
- C. Legitimacy
- D. Influence

Answer: D

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs a **softer capacity to shape choices or conduct without necessarily relying on sanctions; this is the useful exam distinction from coercive power**. with **Influence**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 5

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Force / coercion**?

- A. compliance secured through fear, sanctions or compulsion; Gauba says force is typically used when legitimacy fails (PDF pp.302-303).
- B. trace political power to economic power rooted in ownership of the means of social production and class domination (PDF pp.308-309).
- C. in *Power: A Radical View* (1974), Lukes goes a step further than Bachrach and Baratz: power-holders can shape and manipulate the very wants and preferences of others, such that people's "real interests" are suppressed without any visible conflict, decision or even agenda exclusion (PDF p.318).
- D. (in Macpherson's company here, not a separate elite/class theorist): his 1925 Young India formulation of Swaraj as "the acquisition of the capacity by all to resist authority when it is abused" is Gauba's illustration of power redefined "from the point of view of the ruled" - akin to "speaking truth to power" (PDF p.323).

Answer: A

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Force / coercion** with **compliance secured through fear, sanctions or compulsion; Gauba says force is typically used when legitimacy fails (PDF pp.302-303)**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 6

Which mechanism secures compliance through threats, sanctions or compulsion?

- A. Foucault (optional at §6 level; developed further in §14)
- B. Force / coercion
- C. Second (non-decision-making)
- D. Authority

Answer: B

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **compliance secured through fear, sanctions or compulsion; Gauba says force is typically used when legitimacy fails (PDF pp.302-303)**. with **Force / coercion**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 7

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Legitimacy**?

- A. political power uses state and public decision structures; economic power rests on control over production and resources; ideological power legitimizes rule through beliefs and values (PDF pp.304-306).

B. adds hegemony, civil society and structures of legitimation to explain why capitalist rule survives through consent as well as coercion (PDF pp.306, 309-311).

C. the quality by which rules or decisions are treated as right, good or beneficial, producing willing compliance (PDF p.303).

D. not present in Gauba's chapter.

Answer: C

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Legitimacy** with **the quality by which rules or decisions are treated as right, good or beneficial, producing willing compliance (PDF p.303)**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 8

Which quality makes a rule or decision accepted as rightful, good or beneficial?

A. Feminist theory of power

B. Power

C. Hegemony

D. Legitimacy

Answer: D

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **the quality by which rules or decisions are treated as right, good or beneficial, producing willing compliance (PDF p.303)** with **Legitimacy**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 9

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Authority**?

A. power regarded as rightful and therefore more stable and effective than naked coercion; Gauba's formula is authority = power + legitimacy (PDF p.303).

B. coercion belongs to state-enforced domination; hegemony works through consent cultivated in civil society (PDF pp.310-311).

C. Gaetano Mosca, in *The Ruling Class* (1896), argued every society divides into rulers and ruled, and that the ruling minority's defining strength is its organisational capacity ("organised minority" governing an unorganised majority), not mere intelligence as in Pareto.

D. A 1980 UN report figure on women's work-hours/income/property share is cited by Gauba as a (book-period) illustration of the scale of this exploitation (PDF p.316).

Answer: A

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Authority** with **power regarded as rightful and therefore more stable and effective than naked coercion; Gauba's formula is authority = power + legitimacy (PDF p.303)**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 10

Which concept is captured by Gauba's formula power plus legitimacy?

A. Arendt

B. Authority

C. Influence

D. Power vs authority

Answer: B

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **power regarded as rightful and therefore more stable and effective than naked coercion; Gauba's formula is authority = power + legitimacy (PDF p.303)** with **Authority**.

The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 11

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Hegemony**?

- A. the first highlights domination by an agent over a subject; the second highlights the subject's capacity for resistance and self-development.
- B. Robert Michels, in *Political Parties* (1911), propounded the "Iron Law of Oligarchy": organisations - however democratic their founding aims - tend toward rule by a chosen few because growing size and complexity hand management to professional experts who become difficult to displace.
- C. for Gramsci, a form of rule apparently exercised with the consent of the ruled through cultural and ideological domination (PDF pp.306, 310).
- D. Arendt's own formula: power sustains the "public realm"; violence threatens it; "where genuine power is absent, violence may emerge to fill the gap," and "violence can destroy power; it is utterly incapable of creating it" (PDF pp.320-321).

Answer: C

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Hegemony** with **for Gramsci, a form of rule apparently exercised with the consent of the ruled through cultural and ideological domination (PDF pp.306, 310)**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 12

Which Gramscian concept explains domination organised through consent, culture and civil society?

- A. C.B. Macpherson
- B. Force / coercion
- C. Influence vs force
- D. Hegemony

Answer: D

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **for Gramsci, a form of rule apparently exercised with the consent of the ruled through cultural and ideological domination (PDF pp.306, 310)**. with **Hegemony**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 13

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Power vs authority**?

- A. power can compel obedience; authority secures obedience as rightful and beneficial (PDF p.303).
- B. compliance secured through fear, sanctions or compulsion; Gauba says force is typically used when legitimacy fails (PDF pp.302-303).
- C. influence works by persuasion, prestige or agenda-shaping; force works by threat or sanction.
- D. adds hegemony, civil society and structures of legitimation to explain why capitalist rule survives through consent as well as coercion (PDF pp.306, 309-311).

Answer: A

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Power vs authority** with **power can compel obedience; authority secures obedience as rightful and beneficial (PDF p.303)**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 14

Which distinction separates capacity to compel from power accepted as rightful?

- A. Gandhi
- B. Power vs authority

C. Legitimacy

D. Political vs economic vs ideological power

Answer: B

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **power can compel obedience; authority secures obedience as rightful and beneficial (PDF p.303)**. with **Power vs authority**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 15

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Influence vs force**?

A. trace political power to economic power rooted in ownership of the means of social production and class domination (PDF pp.308-309).

B. in *Power: A Radical View* (1974), Lukes goes a step further than Bachrach and Baratz: power-holders can shape and manipulate the very wants and preferences of others, such that people's "real interests" are suppressed without any visible conflict, decision or even agenda exclusion (PDF p.318).

C. influence works by persuasion, prestige or agenda-shaping; force works by threat or sanction.

D. (in Macpherson's company here, not a separate elite/class theorist): his 1925 *Young India* formulation of Swaraj as "the acquisition of the capacity by all to resist authority when it is abused" is Gauba's illustration of power redefined "from the point of view of the ruled" - akin to "speaking truth to power" (PDF p.323).

Answer: C

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Influence vs force** with **influence works by persuasion, prestige or agenda-shaping; force works by threat or sanction**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 16

Which distinction separates persuasion and prestige from threat and sanction?

A. Second (non-decision-making)

B. Authority

C. Coercion vs hegemony

D. Influence vs force

Answer: D

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **influence works by persuasion, prestige or agenda-shaping; force works by threat or sanction**. with **Influence vs force**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 17

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Political vs economic vs ideological power**?

A. political power uses state and public decision structures; economic power rests on control over production and resources; ideological power legitimizes rule through beliefs and values (PDF pp.304-306).

B. not present in Gauba's chapter.

C. Which issues never reach the agenda at all

D. coercion belongs to state-enforced domination; hegemony works through consent cultivated in civil society (PDF pp.310-311).

Answer: A

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Political vs economic vs ideological power** with **political power uses state and public decision structures; economic power rests on control over production and resources;**

ideological power legitimizes rule through beliefs and values (PDF pp.304-306). The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 18

Which three-part distinction locates power in public decisions, resource ownership and legitimating belief?

- A. Power
- B. Political vs economic vs ideological power
- C. Hegemony
- D. Power over vs power to

Answer: B

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **political power uses state and public decision structures; economic power rests on control over production and resources; ideological power legitimizes rule through beliefs and values (PDF pp.304-306).** with **Political vs economic vs ideological power.** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 19

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Coercion vs hegemony**?

- A. Gaetano Mosca, in *The Ruling Class* (1896), argued every society divides into rulers and ruled, and that the ruling minority's defining strength is its organisational capacity ("organised minority" governing an unorganised majority), not mere intelligence as in Pareto.
- B. A 1980 UN report figure on women's work-hours/income/property share is cited by Gauba as a (book-period) illustration of the scale of this exploitation (PDF p.316).
- C. coercion belongs to state-enforced domination; hegemony works through consent cultivated in civil society (PDF pp.310-311).
- D. the ability to produce intended effects or secure compliance; Gauba cites Russell, Dahl, Wiseman and MacIver to show its coercive and relational dimensions (PDF pp.302-303).

Answer: C

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Coercion vs hegemony** with **coercion belongs to state-enforced domination; hegemony works through consent cultivated in civil society (PDF pp.310-311).** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 20

Which distinction separates state-enforced compulsion from consent cultivated in civil society?

- A. Influence
- B. Power vs authority
- C. Max Weber
- D. Coercion vs hegemony

Answer: D

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **coercion belongs to state-enforced domination; hegemony works through consent cultivated in civil society (PDF pp.310-311).** with **Coercion vs hegemony.** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 21

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Power over vs power to**?

- A. the first highlights domination by an agent over a subject; the second highlights the subject's capacity for resistance and self-development.

B. Robert Michels, in *Political Parties* (1911), propounded the "Iron Law of Oligarchy": organisations - however democratic their founding aims - tend toward rule by a chosen few because growing size and complexity hand management to professional experts who become difficult to displace.

C. identifies traditional, charismatic and legal-rational authority; the last is central to the modern bureaucratic state (PDF p.303).

D. compliance secured through fear, sanctions or compulsion; Gauba says force is typically used when legitimacy fails (PDF pp.302-303).

Answer: A

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Power over vs power to** with **the first highlights domination by an agent over a subject; the second highlights the subject's capacity for resistance and self-development**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 22

Which distinction contrasts domination of others with capacity for resistance and self-development?

A. Force / coercion

B. Power over vs power to

C. Influence vs force

D. Marx and Engels

Answer: B

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **the first highlights domination by an agent over a subject; the second highlights the subject's capacity for resistance and self-development**. with **Power over vs power to**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 23

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Max Weber**?

A. in *The Power Elite* (1956), Mills replaces the Marxian "ruling class" (a single economic class) with "power elite" - three loosely interlocking groups (captains of industry, military leaders, prominent politicians) who occupy the pivotal command posts of modern American society and share social origins, culture and mutual reinforcement, without being reducible to one class (PDF pp.314-315).

B. Macpherson, in *Democratic Theory - Essays in Retrieval* (1973), distinguishes extractive power ("power over" others - the ability to use others' capacities for one's own purpose, historically the Western tradition's dominant focus from Machiavelli to James Mill) from developmental power (a person's ability to use their own capacities - rational understanding, moral judgment, aesthetic activity, love/friendship, productive labour - for self-chosen, self-fulfilling goals).

C. identifies traditional, charismatic and legal-rational authority; the last is central to the modern bureaucratic state (PDF p.303).

D. compliance secured through fear, sanctions or compulsion; Gauba says force is typically used when legitimacy fails (PDF pp.302-303).

Answer: C

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Max Weber** with **identifies traditional, charismatic and legal-rational authority; the last is central to the modern bureaucratic state (PDF p.303)**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 24

Who classifies traditional, charismatic and legal-rational authority as ideal types?

A. Legitimacy

B. Political vs economic vs ideological power

C. Antonio Gramsci

D. Max Weber

Answer: D

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **identifies traditional, charismatic and legal-rational authority; the last is central to the modern bureaucratic state (PDF p.303)**. with **Max Weber**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 25

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Marx and Engels**?

A. trace political power to economic power rooted in ownership of the means of social production and class domination (PDF pp.308-309).

B. in Power: A Radical View (1974), Lukes goes a step further than Bachrach and Baratz: power-holders can shape and manipulate the very wants and preferences of others, such that people's "real interests" are suppressed without any visible conflict, decision or even agenda exclusion (PDF p.318).

C. (in Macpherson's company here, not a separate elite/class theorist): his 1925 Young India formulation of Swaraj as "the acquisition of the capacity by all to resist authority when it is abused" is Gauba's illustration of power redefined "from the point of view of the ruled" - akin to "speaking truth to power" (PDF p.323).

D. the quality by which rules or decisions are treated as right, good or beneficial, producing willing compliance (PDF p.303).

Answer: A

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Marx and Engels** with **trace political power to economic power rooted in ownership of the means of social production and class domination (PDF pp.308-309)**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 26

Who locate political power in class ownership and control of the means of social production?

A. Authority

B. Marx and Engels

C. Coercion vs hegemony

D. Gaetano Mosca

Answer: B

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **trace political power to economic power rooted in ownership of the means of social production and class domination (PDF pp.308-309)**. with **Marx and Engels**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 27

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Antonio Gramsci**?

A. not present in Gauba's chapter.

B. Which issues never reach the agenda at all

C. adds hegemony, civil society and structures of legitimation to explain why capitalist rule survives through consent as well as coercion (PDF pp.306, 309-311).

D. power regarded as rightful and therefore more stable and effective than naked coercion; Gauba's formula is authority = power + legitimacy (PDF p.303).

Answer: C

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Antonio Gramsci** with **adds hegemony, civil society and structures of legitimation to explain why capitalist rule survives through consent as well as coercion (PDF**

pp.306, 309-311). The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 28

Who adds civil society, cultural leadership and hegemony to the analysis of class power?

- A. Hegemony
- B. Power over vs power to
- C. Robert Michels
- D. Antonio Gramsci

Answer: D

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **adds hegemony, civil society and structures of legitimation to explain why capitalist rule survives through consent as well as coercion (PDF pp.306, 309-311).** with **Antonio Gramsci**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 29

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Gaetano Mosca**?

- A. Gaetano Mosca, in *The Ruling Class* (1896), argued every society divides into rulers and ruled, and that the ruling minority's defining strength is its organisational capacity ("organised minority" governing an unorganised majority), not mere intelligence as in Pareto.
- B. A 1980 UN report figure on women's work-hours/income/property share is cited by Gauba as a (book-period) illustration of the scale of this exploitation (PDF p.316).
- C. the ability to produce intended effects or secure compliance; Gauba cites Russell, Dahl, Wiseman and MacIver to show its coercive and relational dimensions (PDF pp.302-303).
- D. for Gramsci, a form of rule apparently exercised with the consent of the ruled through cultural and ideological domination (PDF pp.306, 310).

Answer: A

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Gaetano Mosca** with **Gaetano Mosca, in *The Ruling Class* (1896), argued every society divides into rulers and ruled, and that the ruling minority's defining strength is its organisational capacity ("organised minority" governing an unorganised majority), not mere intelligence as in Pareto.** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 30

Who explains ruling-minority advantage through the organisation of a minority over an unorganised majority?

- A. Power vs authority
- B. Gaetano Mosca
- C. Max Weber
- D. C. Wright Mills

Answer: B

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Gaetano Mosca, in *The Ruling Class* (1896), argued every society divides into rulers and ruled, and that the ruling minority's defining strength is its organisational capacity ("organised minority" governing an unorganised majority), not mere intelligence as in Pareto.** with **Gaetano Mosca**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 31

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Robert Michels**?

- A. Arendt's own formula: power sustains the "public realm"; violence threatens it; "where genuine power is absent, violence may emerge to fill the gap," and "violence can destroy power; it is utterly incapable of creating it" (PDF pp.320-321).

B. a softer capacity to shape choices or conduct without necessarily relying on sanctions; this is the useful exam distinction from coercive power.

C. Robert Michels, in *Political Parties* (1911), propounded the "Iron Law of Oligarchy": organisations - however democratic their founding aims - tend toward rule by a chosen few because growing size and complexity hand management to professional experts who become difficult to displace.

D. power can compel obedience; authority secures obedience as rightful and beneficial (PDF p.303).

Answer: C

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Robert Michels** with **Robert Michels, in Political Parties (1911), propounded the "Iron Law of Oligarchy": organisations - however democratic their founding aims - tend toward rule by a chosen few because growing size and complexity hand management to professional experts who become difficult to displace.** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 32

Who identifies an organisational tendency toward oligarchic leadership as size and managerial expertise grow?

A. Influence vs force

B. Marx and Engels

C. Steven Lukes - the "third dimension of power"

D. Robert Michels

Answer: D

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Robert Michels, in Political Parties (1911), propounded the "Iron Law of Oligarchy": organisations - however democratic their founding aims - tend toward rule by a chosen few because growing size and complexity hand management to professional experts who become difficult to displace.** with **Robert Michels**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 33

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **C. Wright Mills**?

A. in *The Power Elite* (1956), Mills replaces the Marxian "ruling class" (a single economic class) with "power elite" - three loosely interlocking groups (captains of industry, military leaders, prominent politicians) who occupy the pivotal command posts of modern American society and share social origins, culture and mutual reinforcement, without being reducible to one class (PDF pp.314-315).

B. Macpherson, in *Democratic Theory - Essays in Retrieval* (1973), distinguishes extractive power ("power over" others - the ability to use others' capacities for one's own purpose, historically the Western tradition's dominant focus from Machiavelli to James Mill) from developmental power (a person's ability to use their own capacities - rational understanding, moral judgment, aesthetic activity, love/friendship, productive labour - for self-chosen, self-fulfilling goals).

C. compliance secured through fear, sanctions or compulsion; Gauba says force is typically used when legitimacy fails (PDF pp.302-303).

D. influence works by persuasion, prestige or agenda-shaping; force works by threat or sanction.

Answer: A

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **C. Wright Mills** with **in The Power Elite (1956), Mills replaces the Marxian "ruling class" (a single economic class) with "power elite" - three loosely interlocking groups (captains of industry, military leaders, prominent politicians) who occupy the pivotal command posts of modern American society and share social origins, culture and mutual reinforcement, without being reducible to one class (PDF pp.314-315).** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 34

Who identifies interlocking command positions in industry, military leadership and politics as a power elite?

- A. Political vs economic vs ideological power
- B. C. Wright Mills
- C. Antonio Gramsci
- D. Foucault (optional at §6 level; developed further in §14)

Answer: B

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs in **The Power Elite (1956)**, Mills replaces the Marxian "ruling class" (a single economic class) with "power elite" - three loosely interlocking groups (captains of industry, military leaders, prominent politicians) who occupy the pivotal command posts of modern American society and share social origins, culture and mutual reinforcement, without being reducible to one class (PDF pp.314-315). with **C. Wright Mills**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 35

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Steven Lukes - the "third dimension of power"**?

- A. the quality by which rules or decisions are treated as right, good or beneficial, producing willing compliance (PDF p.303).
- B. adds hegemony, civil society and structures of legitimation to explain why capitalist rule survives through consent as well as coercion (PDF pp.306, 309-311).
- C. in **Power: A Radical View (1974)**, Lukes goes a step further than Bachrach and Baratz: power-holders can shape and manipulate the very wants and preferences of others, such that people's "real interests" are suppressed without any visible conflict, decision or even agenda exclusion (PDF p.318).
- D. coercion belongs to state-enforced domination; hegemony works through consent cultivated in civil society (PDF pp.310-311).

Answer: C

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Steven Lukes - the "third dimension of power"** with in **Power: A Radical View (1974)**, Lukes goes a step further than Bachrach and Baratz: power-holders can shape and manipulate the very wants and preferences of others, such that people's "real interests" are suppressed without any visible conflict, decision or even agenda exclusion (PDF p.318). The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 36

Who argues that power may shape wants and perceived interests without visible conflict or agenda exclusion?

- A. Coercion vs hegemony
- B. Gaetano Mosca
- C. Feminist theory of power
- D. Steven Lukes - the "third dimension of power"

Answer: D

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs in **Power: A Radical View (1974)**, Lukes goes a step further than Bachrach and Baratz: power-holders can shape and manipulate the very wants and preferences of others, such that people's "real interests" are suppressed without any visible conflict, decision or even agenda exclusion (PDF p.318). with **Steven Lukes - the "third dimension of power"**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 37

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Foucault (optional at §6 level; developed further in §14)**?

- A. not present in Gauba's chapter.
- B. Which issues never reach the agenda at all
- C. power regarded as rightful and therefore more stable and effective than naked coercion; Gauba's formula is authority = power + legitimacy (PDF p.303).
- D. coercion belongs to state-enforced domination; hegemony works through consent cultivated in civil society (PDF pp.310-311).

Answer: A

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Foucault (optional at §6 level; developed further in §14)** with **not present in Gauba's chapter**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 38

Who is used as a later extension for diffuse productive power, power-knowledge and panoptic self-policing?

- A. Power over vs power to
- B. Foucault (optional at §6 level; developed further in §14)
- C. Robert Michels
- D. Arendt

Answer: B

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **not present in Gauba's chapter** with **Foucault (optional at §6 level; developed further in §14)**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 39

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Feminist theory of power - reconstructed accurately**?

- A. the ability to produce intended effects or secure compliance; Gauba cites Russell, Dahl, Wiseman and MacIver to show its coercive and relational dimensions (PDF pp.302-303).
- B. for Gramsci, a form of rule apparently exercised with the consent of the ruled through cultural and ideological domination (PDF pp.306, 310).
- C. A 1980 UN report figure on women's work-hours/income/property share is cited by Gauba as a (book-period) illustration of the scale of this exploitation (PDF p.316).
- D. the first highlights domination by an agent over a subject; the second highlights the subject's capacity for resistance and self-development.

Answer: C

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Feminist theory of power - reconstructed accurately** with **A 1980 UN report figure on women's work-hours/income/property share is cited by Gauba as a (book-period) illustration of the scale of this exploitation (PDF p.316)**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 40

Which perspective locates power in culture, sexuality, household labour and labour-market structures as well as formal institutions?

- A. Max Weber
- B. C. Wright Mills
- C. C.B. Macpherson

Answer: D

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **A 1980 UN report figure on women's work-hours/income/property share is cited by Gauba as a (book-period) illustration of the scale of this exploitation (PDF p.316).** with **Feminist theory of power.** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 41

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Arendt**?

- A. Arendt's own formula: power sustains the "public realm"; violence threatens it; "where genuine power is absent, violence may emerge to fill the gap," and "violence can destroy power; it is utterly incapable of creating it" (PDF pp.320-321).
- B. a softer capacity to shape choices or conduct without necessarily relying on sanctions; this is the useful exam distinction from coercive power.
- C. power can compel obedience; authority secures obedience as rightful and beneficial (PDF p.303).
- D. identifies traditional, charismatic and legal-rational authority; the last is central to the modern bureaucratic state (PDF p.303).

Answer: A

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Arendt** with **Arendt's own formula: power sustains the "public realm"; violence threatens it; "where genuine power is absent, violence may emerge to fill the gap," and "violence can destroy power; it is utterly incapable of creating it" (PDF pp.320-321).** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 42

Who treats power as collective action in concert and violence as incapable of creating genuine power?

- A. Marx and Engels
- B. Arendt
- C. Steven Lukes - the "third dimension of power"
- D. Gandhi

Answer: B

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Arendt's own formula: power sustains the "public realm"; violence threatens it; "where genuine power is absent, violence may emerge to fill the gap," and "violence can destroy power; it is utterly incapable of creating it" (PDF pp.320-321).** with **Arendt.** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 43

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **C.B. Macpherson**?

- A. compliance secured through fear, sanctions or compulsion; Gauba says force is typically used when legitimacy fails (PDF pp.302-303).
- B. influence works by persuasion, prestige or agenda-shaping; force works by threat or sanction.
- C. Macpherson, in *Democratic Theory - Essays in Retrieval* (1973), distinguishes extractive power ("power over" others - the ability to use others' capacities for one's own purpose, historically the Western tradition's dominant focus from Machiavelli to James Mill) from developmental power (a person's ability to use their own capacities - rational understanding, moral judgment, aesthetic activity, love/friendship, productive labour - for self-chosen, self-fulfilling goals).
- D. trace political power to economic power rooted in ownership of the means of social production and class domination (PDF pp.308-309).

Answer: C

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **C.B. Macpherson** with **Macpherson, in Democratic Theory - Essays in Retrieval (1973)**, distinguishes extractive power ("power over" others - the ability to use others' capacities for one's own purpose, historically the Western tradition's dominant focus from Machiavelli to James Mill) from developmental power (a person's ability to use their own capacities - rational understanding, moral judgment, aesthetic activity, love/friendship, productive labour - for self-chosen, self-fulfilling goals). The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 44

Who distinguishes extractive power over others from developmental power to exercise one's own capacities?

- A. Antonio Gramsci
- B. Foucault (optional at §6 level; developed further in §14)
- C. Second (non-decision-making)
- D. C.B. Macpherson

Answer: D

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Macpherson, in Democratic Theory - Essays in Retrieval (1973)**, distinguishes extractive power ("power over" others - the ability to use others' capacities for one's own purpose, historically the Western tradition's dominant focus from Machiavelli to James Mill) from developmental power (a person's ability to use their own capacities - rational understanding, moral judgment, aesthetic activity, love/friendship, productive labour - for self-chosen, self-fulfilling goals). with **C.B. Macpherson**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 45

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Gandhi**?

- A. (in Macpherson's company here, not a separate elite/class theorist): his 1925 Young India formulation of Swaraj as "the acquisition of the capacity by all to resist authority when it is abused" is Gauba's illustration of power redefined "from the point of view of the ruled" - akin to "speaking truth to power" (PDF p.323).
- B. the quality by which rules or decisions are treated as right, good or beneficial, producing willing compliance (PDF p.303).
- C. political power uses state and public decision structures; economic power rests on control over production and resources; ideological power legitimizes rule through beliefs and values (PDF pp.304-306).
- D. adds hegemony, civil society and structures of legitimation to explain why capitalist rule survives through consent as well as coercion (PDF pp.306, 309-311).

Answer: A

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Gandhi** with (in Macpherson's company here, not a separate elite/class theorist): his 1925 Young India formulation of Swaraj as "the acquisition of the capacity by all to resist authority when it is abused" is Gauba's illustration of power redefined "from the point of view of the ruled" - akin to "speaking truth to power" (PDF p.323). The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 46

Who defines swaraj through the capacity of all to resist authority when it is abused?

- A. Gaetano Mosca
- B. Gandhi
- C. Feminist theory of power
- D. Power

Answer: B

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs (in Macpherson's company here, not a separate elite/class theorist): his 1925 Young India formulation of Swaraj as "the acquisition of the capacity by all to resist authority when it is abused" is Gauba's illustration of power redefined "from the point of view of the ruled" - akin to "speaking truth to power" (PDF p.323). with Gandhi. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 47

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Second (non-decision-making)**?

- A. power regarded as rightful and therefore more stable and effective than naked coercion; Gauba's formula is authority = power + legitimacy (PDF p.303).
- B. coercion belongs to state-enforced domination; hegemony works through consent cultivated in civil society (PDF pp.310-311).
- C. Which issues never reach the agenda at all
- D. Gaetano Mosca, in The Ruling Class (1896), argued every society divides into rulers and ruled, and that the ruling minority's defining strength is its organisational capacity ("organised minority" governing an unorganised majority), not mere intelligence as in Pareto.

Answer: C

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Second (non-decision-making)** with **Which issues never reach the agenda at all**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 48

Which dimension of power asks which important issues are prevented from reaching the agenda?

- A. Robert Michels
- B. Arendt
- C. Influence
- D. Second (non-decision-making)

Answer: D

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Which issues never reach the agenda at all** with **Second (non-decision-making)**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQ STATUS

No directly owned verified UPSC PYQ is assigned to this Political Theory topic. Political Theory is a conceptual-support repository, and the source mapping expressly prohibits proxy, alias or synthetic PYQ routing. The questions below are therefore labelled as original practice, not PYQs.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original Mains Practice 1 - 10 marks

Question: Distinguish power, authority, legitimacy and influence. Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

Introduction: The four concepts describe different mechanisms of securing effects or compliance and should not be used as interchangeable synonyms.

Core analysis: Power is the capacity to produce intended effects or make others comply, whether through resources, sanctions, organisation or control. Influence is a softer capacity to shape conduct through persuasion, prestige or agenda-setting without direct compulsion. Legitimacy is the accepted rightfulness or beneficial character of a rule or

decision. Authority is legitimate power: Gauba's formula, authority equals power plus legitimacy, explains why willing compliance is normally more durable and less costly than naked force. Hegemony complicates the picture because consent may be culturally organised rather than independently reasoned.

Critical evaluation: The distinctions are analytical rather than airtight. Influence can rest on hidden asymmetry, legality can exist without legitimacy, and accepted authority can be challenged where preferences themselves have been shaped by domination.

Conclusion: Power names capacity, influence names non-coercive shaping, legitimacy names accepted rightfulness, and authority joins power to legitimacy; collapsing them conceals how compliance is actually secured.

Why this earns marks: It defines the issue, states the controlling distinction, adds one limitation and closes with a direct verdict suited to a 10-mark answer.

Original Mains Practice 2 - 10 marks

Question: Explain Weber's three types of authority and their limits as pure categories. Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

Introduction: Weber classifies authority by the belief that makes obedience appear rightful rather than by the policy goals of a regime.

Core analysis: Traditional authority rests on established custom and inherited status; hereditary or dynastic rule is the standard illustration. Charismatic authority rests on belief in the extraordinary qualities of a leader and is unstable unless routinised into offices or tradition. Legal-rational authority rests on impersonal rules, competence and office: a civil servant, judge or elected official is obeyed because the office and procedure are accepted as valid. It is central to modern bureaucracy because obedience attaches to a rule-bound role rather than a person.

Critical evaluation: Weber's categories are ideal types, not claims that actual regimes are pure. Bureaucracies retain tradition, electoral systems mobilise charisma and legal procedures may secure belief without substantive justice. Classification explains legitimacy beliefs; it does not prove their moral adequacy.

Conclusion: Traditional, charismatic and legal-rational authority identify rival bases of legitimate obedience, but actual regimes combine them and must still answer whether accepted rule is justified rather than merely believed.

Why this earns marks: It defines the issue, states the controlling distinction, adds one limitation and closes with a direct verdict suited to a 10-mark answer.

Original Mains Practice 3 - 15 marks

Question: Critically examine elite theory with reference to Pareto, Mosca, Michels and C. Wright Mills. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

Introduction: Elite theory challenges the democratic image of equal popular rule by arguing that organised minorities occupy decisive positions in every complex society.

Core analysis: Pareto distinguishes governing and non-governing elites and explains change through circulation, including the contrasting styles of lions and foxes. Mosca locates minority advantage in organisation: an organised minority governs an unorganised majority, though leadership can emerge from different strata. Michels shifts attention from personnel to organisation. Size, expertise and managerial indispensability generate an oligarchic tendency even in parties founded democratically. This does not logically prevent leadership turnover; elites may circulate while control remains oligarchic. C. Wright Mills identifies a power elite occupying interlocking command posts in American industry, military leadership and politics rather than one homogeneous economic class.

Further development: The democratic objection should be specified rather than asserted. Leadership, expertise and organisation are unavoidable in large institutions; the problem is insulation from removal, control of information and conversion of office into self-reproduction. Competitive recruitment may circulate elites without empowering masses, while internal elections may exist without effective challenge. The theory becomes useful when it identifies mechanisms and variation; it becomes ideological when it treats every attempt at accountability as merely another disguise for inevitable minority rule.

Critical evaluation: Elite theory exposes organisation and institutional position, but inevitability can become circular. Gauba's own objection to Michels is decisive: oligarchy varies across organisations, so the iron law is a strong tendency to test, not proof that democratic contestability is impossible.

Conclusion: Elite theory reveals organised minority rule and command positions, but circulation of leaders, oligarchic organisation and interlocking institutional elites are distinct claims whose empirical reach must remain qualified.

Why this earns marks: It combines definition, named doctrinal evidence, comparison and a counter-position before giving a qualified 15-mark verdict.

Original Mains Practice 4 - 15 marks

Question: Does pluralism adequately explain political power? Discuss through the three-dimensional power ladder. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

Introduction: Pluralism explains power through competition among multiple groups, but its adequacy depends on whether power is limited to visible decisions.

Core analysis: The first dimension studies observable conflict: who participates, whose preference prevails and whether different groups win on different issues. Dahl's polyarchic model captures bargaining and the absence of one permanently victorious actor. The second dimension, associated with Bachrach and Baratz, asks which issues are excluded before decision-making begins; agenda control is power even without a recorded contest. Lukes's third dimension goes further by hypothesising that institutions and ideology can shape wants so deeply that subordinate groups neither articulate conflict nor recognise an excluded interest. Gramsci's hegemony supplies a related mechanism of consent formation.

Further development: The dimensions are not simply three interchangeable examples. The first can be studied through visible decisions, the second through excluded issues and institutional rules, and the third through the disputed counterfactual of what people would want under less domination. Because that counterfactual is difficult to establish, third-dimensional analysis should use second-dimensional evidence where possible: defaults, suppressed alternatives, asymmetrical information and barriers to contestation. This preserves Lukes's critical insight without immunising it from evidence.

Critical evaluation: Later pluralists acknowledge unequal resources and business privilege, weakening the claim of neutral group competition. Yet the third dimension risks unfalsifiability: it should be presented as a contested hypothesis supported through observable agenda, default and institutional mechanisms, not asserted as a proven real interest.

Conclusion: Pluralism captures visible group competition, but agenda exclusion and preference shaping reveal progressively deeper forms of domination; the third dimension remains a contested hypothesis rather than a proven diagnosis.

Why this earns marks: It combines definition, named doctrinal evidence, comparison and a counter-position before giving a qualified 15-mark verdict.

Original Mains Practice 5 - 20 marks

Question: Compare Marxist, Gramscian, feminist and pluralist accounts of the location of power. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

Introduction: The four perspectives disagree not only about who possesses power but about the institutions and mechanisms through which domination is reproduced.

Core analysis: Marx and Engels locate political power in economic ownership and class control of social production; state power protects the structural conditions of accumulation. Gramsci preserves material conflict but gives relative autonomy to civil society, where schools, churches, associations and intellectual leadership organise hegemony and consent. Feminist theory relocates power into the supposedly private sphere: culture, sexuality, household labour and labour-market segmentation reproduce patriarchy alongside capitalism. Pluralism instead disperses power among autonomous groups and treats government as mediator, though Dahl and Lindblom later acknowledge unequal

political resources and business privilege. Bachrach-Baratz and Lukes show why visible competition may overlook agenda exclusion and preference shaping.

Further development: Arendt and Macpherson provide a constructive correction to accounts centred on domination. Arendt locates power in collective action and distinguishes it from violence; Macpherson distinguishes extractive power over others from developmental power to use one's capacities. Gandhi's swaraj as the capacity to resist abused authority supplies an Indian bridge. These additions show that political analysis must ask not only who dominates, but what collective and personal capacities institutions enable.

Critical evaluation: No one location is sufficient. Ownership matters without mechanically deciding every outcome; consent is organised but not total; patriarchy intersects with class; and group competition can be genuine while structurally unequal. Analysis should connect resources, institutions, ideology and resistance.

Conclusion: These perspectives locate power in ownership, hegemony, patriarchy and group competition respectively, so a complete account must connect material resources, consent, intimate structures and institutional contestability.

Why this earns marks: It develops multiple dimensions and named evidence units, tests the strongest objection and reply, and reaches a balanced 20-mark judgment.

Original Mains Practice 6 - 20 marks

Question: How does digital surveillance transform power, authority and legitimacy? Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

Introduction: Digital surveillance is politically significant because it produces effects without relying only on visible command, extending classical power into data, prediction and privately governed infrastructure.

Core analysis: Foucault's panopticism identifies the self-policing mechanism generated when the watched cannot know when observation occurs. Contemporary digital power adds asymmetric knowledge, ranking and visibility control, behavioural prediction, pre-emption and automated discretion. These mechanisms map onto the three-dimensional ladder: decisions allocate outcomes, architecture keeps issues or speakers off the agenda, and personalised environments may shape preferences. Zuboff's surveillance-capitalism vocabulary and Pariser's filter-bubble warning are extensions beyond Gauba, not book quotations. The public-private boundary complicates accountability because contractual platforms may perform speech, visibility and adjudicative functions that resemble government without fitting ordinary electoral control.

Further development: The February 2026 M.A.N.A.V. vision at the India AI Impact Summit provides a cautious official anchor because it joins moral systems, accountable governance and valid or legitimate systems to AI. It can be used as a public standard against which digital power is judged, not as proof that every deployed system meets that standard. A complete answer should also distinguish public authority from private platform power and identify hybrid arrangements where government relies on private infrastructure or private actors perform quasi-governmental functions.

Critical evaluation: Capacity is not authority. Consent to unread, non-negotiable terms may be formally present but substantively thin. Legitimate digital power therefore requires legality, a justified aim, proportionality, meaningful explanation, contestability and answerability. Lukes's third dimension remains a hypothesis; analysis should begin with observable defaults, exclusions and review failures.

Conclusion: Digital surveillance extends power through asymmetric knowledge, ranking and anticipation, but it becomes authority only where consent is meaningful, decisions are contestable and public or private power is answerable under rights-respecting rules.

Why this earns marks: It develops multiple dimensions and named evidence units, tests the strongest objection and reply, and reaches a balanced 20-mark judgment.